

POP3 vs. IMAP

POP3 and IMAP are the predominant protocols of e-mail services. They are popular and hence are supported by most clients. But there are certain advantages and disadvantages with both of them, and here we try to make a general differentiation between the two.

POP3	IMAP
<i>You may encounter the following problems with POP3 access since e-mail needs to be downloaded onto the PC before being displayed:</i> You are required to download all e-mail again when using another PC to check your email. If you need to check e-mail at office as well as home in this way, it can lead to confusion. Depending on the settings of your e-mail client, the downloaded e-mail may be deleted from the server.	Since the email is kept on the server, it has the following benefits: There is no need to download all e-mail when using other PC to check your mail. Unread mail can be easily identified.
During the "Check new mail" process, all messages as well as their attachments will be downloaded to your computer.	A complete message will be downloaded if and only if it is opened for display to access its contents.
While multiple mailboxes can be created on the PC to download the mail, there is only one mailbox on the server that stores all the mail.	IMAP has the provision of letting you create multiple mailboxes on the home PC as well as on the mail server.
Incoming and outgoing messages are filtered and transferred only to local mailboxes.	Incoming and outgoing messages are filtered and transferred to other mailboxes no matter where the mailboxes are located (on the server or on the PC).
Outgoing mail is temporarily stored locally.	Outgoing mail is stored on a mailbox on the mail server and can be accessed from another computer.
While you can delete the messages on the home PC very easily, cleaning up messages from the server requires you to download all messages with the mail client configured to delete mail after downloading.	You can delete messages directly on the server, thus making it more convenient to clean up your mailbox on the server.
If your hard drive crashes, you lose all your e-mails.	Since the mail is stored on the server, you won't lose your mail if your hard drive crashes.
The client connects to the e-mail server for a short period of time, only as long as it takes to download any new messages.	When using IMAP4, the client stays connected to the server as long as the user interface is active and downloads message content on demand. In case of many or large messages, this can result in much faster response times.

Who Delivers?

Of the twelve e-mail clients we tested, we found that many of them are good when catering to a particular segment of users. We therefore break away from the tradition of crowning a Gold and Silver winner. Instead, we will mention the noteworthy ones here—the ones we think are worth a try.

Windows comes with Outlook Express 6.0 as the default e-mail client, and though it is buggy and prone to worms and viruses, applying frequent bug-fixes and patches from the Microsoft Web site and using a good anti-virus will minimise the risks. Outlook Express is very simple to use—no wonder there was a hue and cry following rumours in August 2003 that Microsoft had decided to stop further development of Outlook Express: within a week, Microsoft pledged allegiance to its free e-mail client.

If you are always on the move, need to check your e-mails and also carry them around, i.Scribe is the e-mail client for you. Not only does it allow you to password-protect your e-mail folders on a portable drive, it also has advanced features that let you preview your e-mails on the POP3 server without downloading them. This is useful in a scenario where you've run out of free space on your drive, but still want to check new mails

without downloading them. In addition to this, it runs on both Windows and Linux.

If you are a novice or if you are, well, young, IncrediMail Xe with its colourful interface and animated emoticons will surely appeal.

If you are willing to pay for better features, The Bat! should be your choice because it has all the features one might ask of an e-mail client. Corporate users, too, will not be disappointed, because it can connect seamlessly to Microsoft Exchange Server. It even packs in PIM features such as Scheduler and Memo, and at \$25.50 (Rs 1100), the price is not too high.

We have to mention that when it comes to pure performance and compatibility, nothing comes even close to Outlook 2003. This PIM-plus-e-mail client rips the competition apart because of its excellent integration with Windows. It has excellent drag-and-drop support, and integration with components of MS Office. When coupled with MS Exchange Server, Outlook 2003 takes on a whole new avatar as a collaboration tool, complete with the ability to assign tasks to subordinates and delegating correspondence while you take vacations. Corporate users who have the money should definitely opt for it—nothing works better with MS Exchange Server than Outlook 2003. ■

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